

Contoso Corp Employee Handbook

Welcome to Contoso Corp

Contoso Corp is a technology company headquartered in Northlake, Washington, with approximately 4,800 employees across engineering, sales, operations, and support functions. This handbook explains the policies, benefits, and expectations that apply to every Contoso employee, and points you to the standalone policy documents that cover each topic in more depth.

Our mission is to help our customers run their operations more reliably, and we expect every employee to treat that mission, our customers, and each other with integrity, respect, and accountability. Specific expectations for workplace conduct are detailed in the Contoso Corp Code of Conduct and Business Ethics Policy.

Contoso operates from three primary office locations in Northlake, Austin, and Dublin, along with a distributed workforce that spans more than a dozen states and several countries. Regardless of where you are based, the policies in this handbook and its companion documents apply to you unless a specific local addendum, provided by HR at hire, states otherwise.

This handbook is reviewed and updated at least once a year by the People team, with input from Legal and from the executive leadership team, to reflect changes in law, benefits offerings, and company practice. The version you are reading is dated on the HR portal, and prior versions are archived there for reference during disputes or audits.

Nothing in this handbook creates a contract of employment or a guarantee of continued employment, benefits, or compensation. Contoso's employment relationship with each employee is governed by the terms of that employee's individual offer letter and, where applicable, any signed employment agreement, in addition to the policies described here.

If a specific policy document conflicts with a general statement in this handbook, the standalone policy document controls, since it is maintained by the subject-matter team responsible for that topic and updated more frequently than this overview. Employees should treat this handbook as a map to more detailed policies rather than as the final word on any single topic.

Employment Classifications

Every position at Contoso is assigned an employment classification that determines eligibility for overtime, benefits, and certain leave programs; this classification is set by People Operations in partnership with Legal and does not change based on how an individual manager describes the role informally.

Classification decisions are documented in the HR system and communicated in each employee's offer letter. Questions about how a specific classification was determined, or requests to review a classification, should be directed to People Operations rather than resolved informally between an

employee and their manager.

Full-Time and Part-Time Status

Employees who are regularly scheduled for 30 or more hours per week are classified as full-time and are eligible for the full benefits package described in the Contoso Corp Health and Welfare Benefits Guide. Employees scheduled for fewer than 30 hours per week are classified as part-time and are eligible for a prorated subset of benefits.

Scheduled hours, not hours actually worked in a given week, determine full-time or part-time status. An employee whose schedule is reduced for a sustained period, such as a transition to a part-time arrangement following parental leave, is reclassified prospectively once People Operations updates the HR system, and benefits eligibility changes accordingly from that effective date.

Seasonal and temporary employees, who are engaged for a defined period tied to a specific project or peak business need, are treated as part-time for benefits purposes regardless of their weekly hours, unless their assignment is later converted to a regular position.

Managers who want to change an employee's scheduled hours must submit the change through the HR system at least two weeks before it takes effect, so that payroll, benefits, and time-off accrual systems update in the same pay cycle rather than lagging behind the employee's actual schedule.

Managers occasionally ask whether a part-time employee can be temporarily scheduled for full-time hours during a busy period without a formal reclassification; short-term schedule increases of a few weeks do not trigger reclassification, but any increase expected to last more than one full quarter should be submitted as a formal classification change through People Operations so that benefits eligibility and PTO accrual reflect the employee's actual ongoing schedule.

An employee who believes their actual working pattern no longer matches their classification, for example a part-time employee who has been consistently working close to full-time hours for several months, can raise this directly with People Operations for a review, independent of whether their manager has already initiated one.

International employees engaged through a Contoso entity or an approved employer-of-record arrangement follow the full-time and part-time thresholds defined by local law where they differ from the 30-hour standard described above, and People Operations confirms the applicable local threshold at the time of hire.

Interns and co-op employees are classified separately from regular full-time and part-time staff for benefits purposes, and their specific benefits eligibility, which is typically more limited, is described in their individual internship offer rather than in this handbook.

Exempt and Non-Exempt Status

Exempt employees are paid a fixed salary and are not eligible for overtime pay. Non-exempt employees are paid hourly and are eligible for overtime pay in accordance with the Contoso Corp Compensation and Pay Practices Policy. Your offer letter states which classification applies to your role.

Exempt status is determined by the duties and salary level associated with a role, evaluated by the Compensation team against applicable federal and state tests, not by job title alone. Two employees with similar-sounding titles in different functions can carry different classifications if their actual responsibilities differ.

Non-exempt employees are required to record all hours worked, including time spent responding to email or messages outside scheduled hours, using the Contoso timekeeping system. Managers may not ask a non-exempt employee to perform off-the-clock work of any kind, and any employee asked to do so should raise it with HR.

When a role's classification changes, for example following a promotion or a significant change in responsibilities, People Operations notifies the affected employee in writing before the change takes effect and explains any resulting change in how the employee is paid and in overtime eligibility.

The federal and state tests the Compensation team applies generally look at whether a role's primary duties involve executive, administrative, or professional responsibilities exercising independent judgment, as opposed to duties that are more closely directed and supervised; a role's actual day-to-day duties matter more to this analysis than its formal title or reporting level.

Non-exempt employees working across a state line from their manager, for example a remote employee in a state with a different overtime standard than where their team is based, have their classification and overtime rules determined by the state where they physically perform their work, not by where their manager or team is located.

A non-exempt employee who is asked to carry a company phone or laptop for occasional after-hours availability should still record any time actually spent responding to a message or call as working time; simply having a device available does not by itself count as time worked.

Exempt employees do not record hours for overtime purposes, but are still expected to record any PTO, sick leave, or other leave taken through the same HR system used by non-exempt employees, since accurate leave records matter for accrual tracking regardless of exemption status.

Introductory Period

New employees complete a 90-day introductory period during which their manager provides regular feedback on role expectations. Completion of the introductory period does not change employment status; Contoso employment is at-will unless a signed agreement states otherwise.

During the introductory period, managers are expected to hold at least two structured check-ins, at roughly the 30-day and 60-day marks, covering progress against the expectations set out in the Contoso Corp New Hire Onboarding Guide. These check-ins are documented in the performance system even though they fall outside the formal semi-annual review cycle.

An employee transferring internally into a new role from another team at Contoso does not restart a new 90-day introductory period unless the new role sits in a different job family with materially different core duties, in which case People Operations will confirm at the time of the transfer whether a new introductory period applies.

Benefits eligibility, PTO accrual, and other service-based programs begin on an employee's original hire date and are not delayed by the introductory period; the introductory period affects only the cadence of manager feedback and, in limited cases, the process for ending the employment relationship.

Employees hired into a role with a probationary period longer than 90 days due to a professional licensing or certification requirement, such as certain regulated finance or security roles, follow the specific introductory period length stated in their offer letter, which overrides the general 90-day standard described here.

Job Levels and Title Structure

Contoso uses a company-wide job leveling framework, maintained by the Compensation team, that assigns each role a level from entry through senior leadership within its job family, such as engineering, sales, or operations. Levels are intended to be comparable across job families for the purpose of compensation benchmarking, even though the titles associated with a given level can differ by function.

An employee's title is intended to reflect their current level and job family, and title changes generally require a corresponding change in level, approved jointly by the employee's manager, the relevant function lead, and the Compensation team. Managers may not grant an informal title change, such as adding a senior designation to a business card or email signature, without following this process.

Employees can view the leveling framework for their own job family, including the general scope of responsibility expected at each level, through the HR portal. The framework is a useful reference during the review cycle described in the Contoso Corp Performance Management and Review Policy, since promotion decisions are made against these documented level criteria rather than on an ad hoc basis.

Questions about how a specific role was leveled, or requests to be considered for a level change outside the normal review cycle, should go through an employee's manager in the first instance; the manager can escalate to the function lead and Compensation team if warranted, but Compensation does not generally accept leveling requests directly from an individual employee outside that channel.

Workplace Conduct Expectations

The expectations in this section apply to every employee regardless of work location, and are enforced consistently by managers with support from HR. They are meant to set a baseline; individual teams may adopt additional norms, such as core meeting hours, as long as those norms do not conflict with company-wide policy.

Repeated concerns in either area below are addressed first through informal manager coaching, and only escalate to the formal performance management process described in the Contoso Corp Performance Management and Review Policy if the behavior continues after that coaching.

Contractors and agency temporary workers who are on-site or embedded with a Contoso team are expected to follow the same baseline conduct expectations described in this section for the duration

of their engagement, even though their employment relationship, benefits, and performance management are governed by their staffing agency or contracting entity rather than by Contoso directly.

Attendance and Punctuality

Employees are expected to be reliably available during their scheduled hours, whether working on-site or remotely. If you are unable to work as scheduled, notify your manager as far in advance as possible. Repeated unexplained absences are addressed through the performance management process described in the Contoso Corp Performance Management and Review Policy.

Employees who anticipate being late or unable to work a scheduled shift should notify their manager through the channel the team has agreed on, whether that is a chat message, a calendar hold, or a phone call, before the shift is scheduled to begin whenever possible.

Attendance expectations apply equally to remote and hybrid employees; being reachable and available during agreed working hours matters as much as physical presence for employees who work from an office. Managers evaluate attendance based on availability and responsiveness, not on the specific hours logged into a badge system.

A pattern of unplanned absences, defined as three or more unexplained instances within a rolling 90-day period, prompts a documented conversation between the employee and their manager, with HR available to help identify whether an underlying issue, such as a health condition, should instead be handled through the accommodation process described in the Contoso Corp Workplace Accommodation and Anti-Discrimination Policy.

Teams that operate on a fixed customer-facing schedule, such as a support rotation, document their specific coverage requirements separately from this general policy, and an employee on such a team should look to their team's coverage schedule as the specific expression of this policy's attendance expectations for their role.

A manager who needs to step away from standard availability, for example for a medical appointment or a family obligation, is held to the same notice expectations as any other employee; there is no different standard for people managers under this policy.

Extended, planned absences beyond ordinary time off, such as jury duty or an approved leave described in the Contoso Corp Paid Time Off and Leave Policy, are not counted toward the unplanned-absence pattern described above, since they are foreseen and already coordinated with the manager in advance.

Employees traveling across time zones for business purposes, as described in the Contoso Corp Business Travel and Expense Reimbursement Policy, are expected to coordinate with their manager on a reasonable adjusted availability window for the duration of the trip rather than being held to their normal home-time-zone hours.

Dress Code

Contoso maintains a business-casual dress code for employees working from an office location, with adjustments for roles that require safety or client-facing attire. Remote employees have no fixed dress code but should dress appropriately for video meetings.

Employees who interact with customers on-site, or who work in roles covered by a specific safety standard, follow the more specific dress and personal protective equipment requirements described in their team's local procedures, which take precedence over the general business-casual guidance in this handbook.

Contoso does not require specific dress for internal video meetings beyond the general appropriate-for-a-professional-setting standard, and managers are expected to model reasonable flexibility, particularly for employees balancing work with caregiving responsibilities during the workday.

Business-casual at Contoso is intentionally broad: collared shirts, sweaters, blouses, slacks, and clean denim are all acceptable, while attire more suited to the beach or the gym, along with clothing bearing offensive or discriminatory imagery, is not. Managers who have a concern about a specific employee's attire should raise it privately rather than commenting in front of the team.

Religious and cultural dress and grooming practices are accommodated as a matter of course and do not require a formal accommodation request under the Contoso Corp Workplace Accommodation and Anti-Discrimination Policy; managers should not treat religious or cultural attire as a dress code exception needing special approval.

Use of Company Property and Workspaces

Employees are expected to use Contoso-provided office space, shared equipment such as conference rooms and printers, and common areas in a way that leaves them usable for the next person, including cleaning up after meals and returning borrowed equipment such as adapters or projectors to their designated storage location.

Personal use of shared office resources, such as printing a small personal document or using a conference room briefly for a personal call, is permitted within reasonable limits and does not require advance approval; regular or extensive personal use of shared resources that displaces business use should be discussed with a manager.

Office access badges, keys, and parking credentials remain Contoso property and must be returned to Facilities upon a change in work location, an extended leave, or separation from the company. Lost badges should be reported to Facilities immediately so that access can be deactivated promptly.

Employees should not store hazardous materials, personal valuables of significant worth, or perishable food for extended periods in shared or unassigned workspaces; guidance on storage of hazardous materials specific to certain lab or hardware testing spaces is set out in the Contoso Corp Workplace Health and Safety Policy.

Workplace Technology and Equipment

Contoso provides each employee with the equipment reasonably necessary to perform their role, typically a laptop and, for employees working primarily from a home office, a basic peripheral kit such as a monitor, keyboard, and mouse. Requests for equipment beyond this baseline kit are submitted through the IT service portal and are reviewed against role requirements by the employee's manager.

All company-issued equipment remains Contoso property and must be returned upon separation, an extended unpaid leave, or a request from IT for a security or maintenance reason. Employees who do not return equipment within ten business days of separation may have the replacement cost deducted from final pay to the extent permitted by law in their jurisdiction.

Use of company-issued devices and accounts, including acceptable personal use, data handling expectations, and rules for connecting personal devices to Contoso systems, is governed by the Contoso Corp Information Security and Acceptable Use Policy, which every employee is required to acknowledge annually.

Employees who experience a hardware failure, a lost or stolen device, or suspect that a company account has been compromised should contact the IT help desk immediately, and in the case of a lost or stolen device or a suspected compromise, should also notify their manager and Security so that access can be revoked and the incident logged in accordance with the Contoso Corp Information Security and Acceptable Use Policy.

Employees working from a home office are expected to maintain a reasonably secure and private workspace for handling company information, consistent with the standards in the Contoso Corp Remote Work and Flexible Work Arrangements Policy; this does not require a dedicated home office room, but does require that company devices and confidential material not be left accessible to other household members or visitors.

Software installed on a company-issued device must be approved through the IT service portal before installation, except for a short list of pre-approved productivity tools published on the IT wiki; unapproved software, including personal cloud storage or remote access tools, may be removed by IT without advance notice if it is found to pose a security risk.

Employees separating from Contoso, whether voluntarily or involuntarily, are expected to return all company equipment and to refrain from copying company data to a personal device or personal cloud account at any point during their employment; IT reviews device activity logs as part of the standard offboarding process described in the Contoso Corp Information Security and Acceptable Use Policy.

Requests for specialized equipment tied to a documented disability, such as an ergonomic keyboard or an adjustable-height desk, are handled through the accommodation process in the Contoso Corp Workplace Accommodation and Anti-Discrimination Policy rather than through the standard IT equipment request process, so that the request is evaluated on an accelerated timeline appropriate to an accommodation.

Anti-Retaliation

Contoso prohibits retaliation against any employee who, in good faith, reports a suspected policy violation, participates in an investigation, requests a workplace accommodation, files a workers' compensation claim, or exercises any other right protected under this handbook or applicable law. Retaliation includes termination, demotion, undesirable reassignment, exclusion from meetings or projects, or any other adverse action taken because of the protected activity.

This protection applies whether the underlying report is ultimately substantiated or not, as long as it was made in good faith; an employee who raises a concern that turns out, after investigation, to be unfounded is still protected from retaliation for having raised it. A report made maliciously or with knowledge that it is false is not protected and may itself result in disciplinary action.

Employees who believe they have experienced retaliation should report it to HR or through the confidential ethics reporting channel described in the Contoso Corp Code of Conduct and Business Ethics Policy. Retaliation reports are investigated with the same seriousness as the original report and are not handled by the manager who is the subject of the complaint.

Managers found to have retaliated against an employee, even where the manager believed their action was independently justified, are subject to discipline up to and including termination, and HR reviews any adverse action taken against an employee within a short window after that employee's protected activity with particular scrutiny to confirm the action was not retaliatory.

This anti-retaliation commitment applies across all of the reporting channels described elsewhere in this handbook and in related policies, including reports of harassment or discrimination under the Contoso Corp Equal Employment Opportunity and Anti-Harassment Policy, safety concerns under the Contoso Corp Workplace Health and Safety Policy, and ethics or compliance concerns under the Contoso Corp Code of Conduct and Business Ethics Policy.

Company Communications

Contoso relies on a small number of official channels for company-wide communication: an all-hands meeting held at the end of each quarter, a weekly written update from the executive leadership team posted to the HR portal, and time-sensitive announcements sent by email to all employees.

Employees are expected to read company-wide communications within a reasonable time of receipt, generally within two business days.

Team-level communication norms, such as which chat channels a team uses or how quickly a message should be acknowledged, are set by individual managers within the bounds of company-wide policy, and new employees should expect their manager or a designated teammate to walk them through team-specific norms during their first week, consistent with the Contoso Corp New Hire Onboarding Guide.

Employees who wish to raise a concern or ask a question of the executive leadership team directly, outside their own management chain, may do so through the anonymous or attributed suggestion channel on the HR portal; questions submitted through this channel are reviewed weekly and a selection are addressed directly in the quarterly all-hands meeting.

External communications on behalf of Contoso, including statements to the press, public social media posts referencing company business, and public speaking engagements where an employee is identified as a Contoso representative, must be coordinated in advance with the Communications team; this requirement is separate from and in addition to the social media guidance in the Contoso Corp Code of Conduct and Business Ethics Policy.

Employees should not use personal email accounts or personal messaging apps to conduct substantive company business, both because company systems are the record of business communication for legal and audit purposes and because personal accounts do not carry the same security controls described in the Contoso Corp Information Security and Acceptable Use Policy.

Where to Find More Information

This handbook is an overview. Detailed rules for each topic live in their own policy documents, including the Paid Time Off and Leave Policy, the Remote Work and Flexible Work Arrangements Policy, the Information Security and Acceptable Use Policy, and the Workplace Health and Safety Policy. If a specific question is not answered in this handbook, check the relevant standalone policy before assuming an answer, or contact HR at hr@contoso-corp.example.

The HR portal maintains a single, current index of every Contoso policy document, including this handbook, with a version history so employees can confirm they are reading the current version rather than a saved or printed copy. Printed copies of any policy should be treated as a point-in-time reference only.

Employees who believe a policy is being applied inconsistently across teams, rather than simply having a question about how it applies to their own situation, should raise the concern with HR rather than assuming the inconsistency is intentional; HR tracks these reports to identify where manager training or policy clarification is needed.

This handbook and the policies it references are available in accessible formats on request; employees who need an alternate format because of a disability should contact HR, who will coordinate with the Workplace Accommodation and Anti-Discrimination Policy process if an ongoing accommodation is also needed.

Employees new to Contoso often find it easiest to start with the Contoso Corp New Hire Onboarding Guide, which links out to the specific policies most relevant during a first 90 days, rather than trying to read every standalone policy in full before starting.

HR periodically hosts a live policy office-hours session, open to any employee, where questions about how a specific policy applies can be asked directly, in addition to the always-available option of emailing HR directly with a specific question.

Managers are expected to be familiar with the full set of policies referenced in this handbook well enough to point a team member to the right document, even if the manager does not personally know every detailed rule within each one.

This handbook does not attempt to restate every detail already covered in a standalone policy; where this handbook and a standalone policy appear to disagree on a specific point, employees should treat the standalone policy document, not this handbook, as authoritative, and may flag the discrepancy to HR so the handbook can be corrected.

Employees who are unsure which policy governs a specific situation that seems to span more than one topic, for example a request to work remotely while also modifying a work schedule for a medical reason, are encouraged to bring the full situation to HR in one conversation rather than researching each policy independently, since HR can identify which provisions apply together and coordinate across the Contoso Corp Remote Work and Flexible Work Arrangements Policy and the Contoso Corp Workplace Accommodation and Anti-Discrimination Policy as needed.

The Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion Policy and the Equal Employment Opportunity and Anti-Harassment Policy are referenced throughout this handbook because they set expectations that touch nearly every other topic covered here; employees are encouraged to read both in full during onboarding rather than waiting until a specific situation arises to consult them for the first time.

Finally, this handbook is written to be a living document rather than a static one: as Contoso's policies, benefits, and practices evolve, this handbook is updated to match, and employees are notified of material changes through the company communications channels described elsewhere in this handbook rather than being expected to check the HR portal on their own initiative for silent updates.